letter to the chief justice of India, Justice Y.V. Chandrachud, criticizing the decision.[8] The letter written by Upendra Baxi, Vasudha Dhagamwar, Raghunath Kelkar and Lotika Sarkar was a brief, but decisive, inquisition of all aspects of the court's decision. The academics observed that the court's judgement overlooked important factual considerations: that the rape arose from Mathura's wrongful confinement by the police and that Tukaram was intoxicated on duty. They also noted the court's mistaken understanding of the law on rape: '[T]here is a clear difference in law, and common sense, between "submission" and "consent". Consent involves submission; but the converse is not necessarily true.' Perhaps most importantly, they highlighted that the decision was based on chauvinistic assumptions. Mathura's sexual history demonstrated that she was likely to have consented; Ganpat's sexual history was considered evidence of the absence of rape: '[W]hy this double standard? Ganpat's sexual habits give him the benefit of doubt of having raped Mathura; her sexual habits make the Court disbelieve the story of the rape altogether.'

The letter concluded with a plea to have Mathura's case reheard at the Supreme Court by a larger panel of judges, possibly even the whole court. The letter offered the following justification for what the authors themselves described as a 'startlingly unconventional, and even a naive suggestion':

> [N]othing short of protection of human rights and constitutionalism is at stake . . . Maybe on re-examination Ganpat and Tukaram may stand acquitted for better reasons than those now available. But what matters is a search for liberation from the colonial and male-dominated notions of what may constitute the element of consent, and the burden of proof, for rape which affect many Mathuras on the Indian countryside.[9]

The open letter did not manage to capture attention in the weeks after it was sent. One of its authors noted that *Dawn*, a newspaper based in Pakistan, was first among the mainstream media to publish a report based on the letter. The news spread in India quite swiftly thereafter, and Mathura's case became part of the public consciousness within months. Wider awareness about the court's decision and the injustice meted out to Mathura sparked protests across the country. The protests took many forms, including demonstrations, speeches, discussions, poster campaigns, plays